territorial power, and gradually extended its naval reach down along the South American coast, as well.

Next, from off the western American coast all the way across the trackless Pacific to the Philippine and Indonesian archipelagos, a liquid desert confronted American ships. Widely scattered oases, such as the Sandwich (Hawaiian) Islands or atolls and islands of Polynesia, offered stopping points on the months-long voyages. Here, the United States established a "zone of influence." Outside of the Sandwich Islands and occasional larger islands such as Guam, there was little territory to be taken or controlled, unlike in continental America or Asia proper. US naval ships instead sailed freely in and out of these waters, dispatched to convoy American trading ships or to punish violent or recalcitrant Pacific potentates for impeding trade or threatening missionaries. The two Sumatran expeditions during the 1830s were examples of how Americans operated in the zone of influence: exercising US power against smaller or less powerful adversaries but almost always leaving their territory alone throughout the first three-quarters of the nineteenth century.

Finally, when the US Navy reached Asia itself, it encountered a crowded, complex geopolitical region of ancient states, such as China, Japan, and Korea, along with European colonies, such as the Philippines, and dozens or hundreds of smaller principalities. Here, American power was extremely limited, and there was no possibility, let alone desire, to attempt to control territory directly or even have influence to the same degree it did over isolated islands in the middle of the Pacific. Instead, the United States participated in a "zone of cooperation," more often than not working in tandem with European powers to pressure regional states, enter into diplomatic agreements, and occasionally employ force, such as against the Chinese in 1859, during the Second Opium War, and the Japanese in the 1863 Shimonoseki Expedition.[14] Even when the Americans acted unilaterally, as against Formosa in 1867 or Korea in 1871, they were well aware of the limited nature of their military power, as well as the interests of other Western nations, which demanded comparatively restrained US objectives. The apotheosis of American activity